Lights that tell a story

10 minutes together | Optional 5-10 minutes deeper | K-8

להראות ולגלות הנס

To show and make the miracle known.

Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 3:3 | Short excerpt; original English translation.

READ TOGETHER | 3 MIN

The Rambam explains that we light at the entrances of our homes to make the miracle known. This idea is called pirsumei nisa: publicizing the miracle. The light points beyond itself to something worth remembering. Family connection: when someone asks about our Chanukiah, we have a chance to explain why it matters to us, in words they can understand.

ONE HALACHA TO TAKE HOME | 1 MIN

The Gemara describes lighting by an outside entrance, or a window facing the public way for someone living upstairs; in danger, indoors is sufficient. Actual placement depends on the home and family practice. Use a safe, stable location chosen by an adult. Never move a burning Chanukiah for an activity.

TALK & TRY | 4 MIN

Pretend a friendly visitor has never seen a Chanukiah. One partner asks about it; the other explains the oil miracle and why we light. Switch roles. Keep each explanation under one minute.

Younger learners: Point to the shamash from a safe distance. What makes it different?
Older learners: Why might the place of a mitzvah help communicate its meaning? What changes when public display is unsafe?

TELL IT BACK | 2 MIN

1. What does pirsumei nisa mean? 2. In danger, must someone insist on lighting outside?

GO DEEPER | OPTIONAL 5-10 MIN

Compare Shabbat 21b with Rambam 3:3. Identify the purpose and the possible locations. Explain how a mitzvah can keep its purpose while its practical setting changes.

Sources: Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 3:3; Placement and danger: Shabbat 21b.

Turn over for the source texts. Learn with a parent, sibling, grandparent, or another partner. Answer aloud; adults may read. Catch up anytime. Record actual learning minutes after Shabbat; each child submits separately.

Inside the sources

Original Hebrew / Aramaic with original English translations. Excerpts are labeled; ... marks omissions. Read one passage together or explore all of them.

1. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 3:3

Selected passage

ומפני זה התקינו חכמים שבאותו הדור שיהיו שמונת ימים האלו שתחלתן כ"ה בכסליו ימי שמחה והלל ומדליקין בהן הנרות בערב על פתחי הבתים בכל לילה ולילה משמונת הלילות להראות ולגלות הנס.

Therefore, the Sages of that generation established these eight days, beginning on 25 Kislev, as days of joy and praise. On each of the eight nights, lamps are lit in the evening at the entrances of homes, to show and make the miracle known.

2. Shabbat 21b | Place and circumstances

Selected passage

ת"ר נר חנוכה מצוה להניחה על פתח ביתו מבחוץ אם היה דר בעלייה מניחה בחלון הסמוכה לרה"ר ובשעת הסכנה מניחה על שלחנו ודיו

The Sages taught: It is a mitzvah to place the Chanukah lamp outside the entrance to one's home. Someone living upstairs places it at a window facing the public area. In a time of danger, placing it on one's table is sufficient.

3. Rambam, Hilchot Megillah vaChanukah 4:9 | Lighting in place

Selected passage

הדליקו מבפנים והוציאו דלוק והניחו על פתח ביתו לא עשה כלום עד שידליקנו במקומו

If one lit it inside, carried it outside while burning, and placed it at the entrance, one has not fulfilled the mitzvah; it must be lit in its proper place.

DISCUSS THE SOURCES

Find the purpose in Rambam and the possible locations in the Gemara. Why is lighting in the proper place part of communicating the mitzvah?

Read originals online: Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3. Hebrew transcribed from the cited editions; vowel marks omitted and punctuation adjusted for readability.